

CHANGING SCHOOL ATTENDANCE ZONES

The Loudoun County School Board is vested with the authority through the Code of Virginia to provide for the consolidation of schools, the redistricting of school attendance zones, and/or the adoption of student assignment plans whenever such procedure will contribute to the operational efficiency and/or instructional effectiveness of the school division.

The School Board shall assign students to the school and programs that serve the areas of their residences, in accordance with the local school attendance zones and service areas established by the School Board. Exceptions to this policy will be made in accordance with School Board Policies 8155, School Assignment, and 8160, Exceptions to School Assignment Due to Attendance Zone Change.

A. Reasons for Considering Attendance Zone Adjustments. The School Board may change an attendance zone to maintain or improve operating efficiency and/or instructional effectiveness. In general, adjustments may relieve facility crowding, better utilize existing space, avoid underutilized school facilities, better allocate program resources, and/or reduce operating costs.

B. Process for Considering Attendance Zone Adjustments.

1. Evaluation. At least annually, the Superintendent will evaluate whether any school attendance zone changes are to be considered (e.g., new school opening). However, all school attendance zones will be comprehensively reviewed by the School Board every five years to assess student enrollment and school capacity imbalances. Typically, the evaluation will take place within the context of the Capital Improvement Program budget process, but a change may also be recommended at any time to address overcrowding or other instructional concerns. An attendance zone change may also be initiated at the direction of the School Board.

2. Initiation. When conditions exist for an attendance zone change, the Superintendent will recommend to the School Board the schools potentially affected, the means by which the public will be involved, and a calendar for the attendance zone change process. Once a decision is made by the School Board to initiate an attendance zone change process, the School Board will encourage public participation and engagement throughout the process, including establishing a procedure for receiving comment and feedback.

a. Standard Attendance Zone Change Process. A standard attendance zone process will follow an outlined meeting schedule.

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- (i) School Board Attendance Zone Overview. Staff will provide an overview of the attendance zone change process which will include identification of school facility and program issues, student demographics, and enrollment projections. An attendance zone change recommendation(s) will be presented to the School Board for consideration.
- (ii) School Board Public Hearing and Work Session. Staff will update the School Board on the attendance zone plan(s) under consideration by the Board. Following the staff briefing, the School Board will open the hearing for members of the public to provide comment and input regarding the attendance zone plan(s). At the conclusion of the public hearing, the School Board will discuss attendance zone data and solutions, including attendance zone plan(s) under consideration.
- (iii) School Board Public Hearing and Work Session. Staff will update the School Board on the attendance zone plan(s) under consideration by the Board. Following the staff briefing, the School Board will open the hearing for members of the public to provide comment and input regarding the attendance zone plan(s). At the conclusion of the public hearing, the School Board will discuss attendance zone data and solutions, including attendance zone plan(s) under consideration.
- (iv) School Board Recommendation (Information Item). The School Board's attendance zone plan(s) will be placed on the next available School Board meeting agenda, as an Information Item, for review and discussion. Each plan placed on the School Board agenda must have written rationale that highlights the extent and limits to which the plan addresses the factors identified in Section C. The written rationale will be provided by the Board member(s) proposing a plan's consideration.
- (v) Staff Briefing and School Board Public Hearing. Staff will update the School Board on the attendance zone plan(s) currently under consideration by the Board. Following the briefing, the School Board will open the hearing for

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members of the public to provide comment and input regarding the attendance zone plan(s).

- (vi) School Board Action (Action Item). The School Board's attendance zone plan(s) and their associated rationale will be placed on the next available School Board meeting agenda, as an Action Item, for review and adoption.
- b. Abbreviated Attendance Zone Change Process.
 - (i) The Superintendent may recommend an abbreviated attendance zone change process under certain circumstances.
 - (a) School Conversion. The conversion of all or a part of an existing school to a specialized school, such as a public charter, in which a conversion results in the closing, retiring, or consolidating of an existing school.
 - (b) School Consolidation. The consolidation of two or more existing schools, resulting from the closing or retiring of one of the schools that is no longer needed for its educational purpose.
 - (c) New Residential Development. New unoccupied housing requiring an attendance zone change to avoid overcrowding at a school.
 - (d) Minimal Overcrowding and/or Cluster Alignment. If school overcrowding exists or a small percentage of students matriculate together to a secondary school that may be resolved with reassignment of ten (10) percent or less of current student enrollment of the identified school.
 - (e) Emergency Need. An emergency or other overriding public need requiring an attendance zone change.

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- (ii) The Superintendent and/or designee will consult with the School Board members representing the schools identified for an abbreviated attendance zone change. If the School Board members agree to a review of the attendance zone change in an abbreviated process, the process will follow an outlined meeting schedule.
 - (a) School Board Recommendation (Information Item). An attendance zone change recommendation will be presented to the School Board for consideration and will include an overview of school facility and program issues, student demographics, and enrollment projections. Written rationale, prepared by staff, will also accompany the recommendation.
 - (b) Staff Briefing and School Board Public Hearing. Staff will provide an overview of the recommended attendance zone change. Following the briefing, the School Board will open the hearing for members of the public to provide comment and input regarding the attendance zone change recommendation. The public hearing may be held at the same meeting the School Board is scheduled to take action on the attendance zone recommendation.
 - (c) School Board Action (Action Item). At the second regularly scheduled School Board meeting, following introduction of the information item, the recommended attendance zone change and the associated written rationale will be placed on the School Board agenda for review and adoption.
- c. Administrative Attendance Zone Change Process. The Superintendent may initiate an administrative attendance zone change under certain distinct circumstances to address technical inaccuracies and/or practical problems (e.g., land is developed and where a school attendance zone once bisected a field that had no consequence, it now bisects a house). The Superintendent will notify the School Board of all administrative changes at the time of the implementation.

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C. Factors Considered in Attendance Zone Changes. When changing attendance zones, the School Board will consider, but not be limited to, the following criteria whenever possible:

1. Facilities. Effective use of new and existing school facilities.
 - a. Utilize projected student enrollment and school capacity as principal measures of determining efficient use of educational facilities.
 - b. Promote reasonable balancing of student enrollment within the school system to avoid over or underutilization of facilities and to establish an equitable distribution of programs and resources.
 - c. Minimize long-term use of modular classrooms that cause a school to operate at more than its capacity.
 - d. Minimize future capital and operational budget costs.
2. Proximity. Keep students close to their schools.
 - a. Base attendance zones on geographic proximity as measured by distance traveled using established routes of transportation.
 - b. Prioritize assignment of adjacent neighborhoods and communities to a school.
 - c. Promote attendance zones that are contiguous, whenever possible.
 - d. Encourage reasonable walking zones to foster healthier lifestyles, promote a cleaner environment and reduce transportation costs.
3. Community. Encourage the link between schools and communities by promoting the concept of community schools and avoiding the splitting of communities between schools, whenever possible.
4. Accessibility. Identify the reasonable ability for students to attend a school from all portions of the attendance zone, taking into consideration natural and man-made barriers (e.g., major roads, geographic features).

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5. Stability. Promote long-term attendance zone stability. Endeavor to minimize multiple attendance zone changes for a given residence, whenever possible.

6. Cluster Alignment. Support the alignment of elementary, middle and high schools into cohesive operational clusters (unified school feeder system) in which students remain with their educational cohorts to the greatest extent possible.

D. Additional Considerations. The School Board may consider any factors in implementing an attendance zone change. In the exercise of its authority, the School Board recognizes that it may not be reasonably practicable to reconcile each and every factor in any attendance zone change, but any attendance zone plan adopted by the School Board should be based upon the above factors to the greatest extent possible. Other factors that may be considered regarding changing a school attendance zone include impact on students, families, and neighborhoods; long-range capital plans; and socioeconomic characteristics of school population where data is available and usage is permissible by law.

Adopted: 9/25/01

Revised: 2/23/10, 9/25/12, 9/9/14, 8/8/17, 1/11/22

Current Revision: 4/22/25

Leg Refs: Code of Virginia [§22.1-79\(4\) and \(8\)](#), [Virginia Constitution Article VIII, §7](#)
Cross Refs: Policy 4160, Capital Improvement Program
Policy [8155](#), School Assignment
Policy [8160](#), Exceptions to School Assignment Due to Attendance Zone Change